

# A One-Minute Cancer Jab? NHS Patients Get More Time to Garden!

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Imagine spending an hour in a hospital chair for medicine. Now imagine it takes just one minute! That's the change for thousands of cancer patients in the UK. A drug called **Keytruda** helps the body's own **immune system** fight cancer cells. Before, patients got it through a drip into their **vein**. That could take more than an hour. Now, NHS England says a new injection cuts that time to a couple of minutes. Shirley Xerxes, 86, was one of the first to try it. She said she was in the chair "for a matter of minutes instead of an hour or more." She loves that it gives her more time to garden. About 14,000 people in England start **Keytruda** each year. Most will likely switch to the quick jab. The drug treats 14 types of cancer, like lung and breast cancer. The injection is given every three weeks as a one-minute shot, or every six weeks as a two-minute shot. It's the third **immunotherapy** drug that can be given by jab on the NHS. **Immunotherapy** works by stopping cancer's "**invisibility cloak**." Cancer can hide from immune cells by sending a "stop" signal. The drug blocks that signal so the body can attack the cancer. This discovery won a **Nobel Prize** in 2018. **Keytruda** is now the world's top-selling medicine. The new jab saves time for patients and hospital staff. One doctor said it could even let patients get treatment closer to home one day. That's a big win for everyone!

## Word Treasure

**Keytruda** -- A medicine that helps the body's own defense system find and attack cancer cells.

**immune system** -- The body's natural protection against sickness, made of cells that fight germs and bad cells.

**vein** -- A tube inside your body that carries blood back to the heart.

**immunotherapy** -- A type of treatment that teaches the immune system to destroy cancer.

**invisibility cloak** -- A trick cancer uses to hide from the body's fighter cells, like a magic hood.

**Nobel Prize** -- A very famous award given to people who make huge discoveries that help the world.

## Background you need

The NHS (National Health Service) is the UK's system that gives free medical care to everyone who lives there.

Immunotherapy helps the body's own defenses fight diseases; it was named Science magazine's Breakthrough of the Year in 2013.

James Allison and Tasuku Honjo won the 2018 Nobel Prize for discovering how to release the brakes on the immune system, leading to medicines like Keytruda.

## Break it down

**WHO:** Cancer patients in England, like 86-year-old Shirley Xerxes.

**WHAT:** The NHS is using a new one-minute injection of Keytruda instead of an hour-long IV drip.

**WHERE:** In NHS hospitals across England.

**WHY:** To save time for patients and hospital staff, and possibly allow treatment closer to home in the future.

## Why it matters

This story shows how medical advances can give sick people more time for the things they love, like gardening, and that one day a quick jab might let you visit a nurse near home instead of a faraway hospital.

## Test what you remember

1. How long did the old Keytruda treatment usually take?
  - (A) 10 minutes
  - (B) 30 minutes
  - (C) more than an hour
  - (D) 2 hours
2. What is the name of the cancer drug that can now be given as a quick jab?
  - (A) Canceritol
  - (B) Keytruda
  - (C) RAVEN
  - (D) TESS
3. Who was the very first patient to try the new one?minute injection?
  - (A) a scientist
  - (B) a doctor
  - (C) Shirley Xerxes
  - (D) the NHS head
4. About how many people in England start taking Keytruda each year?
  - (A) 1,400
  - (B) 14,000
  - (C) 140,000
  - (D) 1,400,000
5. How often can the two?minute version of the injection be given?
  - (A) every week
  - (B) every three weeks
  - (C) every six weeks
  - (D) every month
6. What discovery won the 2018 Nobel Prize that is mentioned in the article?
  - (A) a new type of injection
  - (B) stopping cancer's 'invisibility cloak' so the body can fight it
  - (C) a faster way to garden
  - (D) a telescope to see stars

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: C 4: B 5: C 6: B

## Questions to think about

1. Patient: Shirley Xerxes said she spent 'a matter of minutes instead of an hour or more' in the chair and was happy to still feel cared for.
2. Doctor: One doctor noted that the quick jab saves staff time and might even let patients get treatment at a local clinic one day instead of a big hospital.
3. NHS manager: The NHS expects most of the 14,000 new patients each year to switch to the injection, which could free up resources for other people who need care.

**MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):**